and it, like its predecessor, could not survive against the inherent drive of all men and women to be free.

Now, the economic statistics and intelligence reports I was getting during my daily National Security Council briefings were revealing tangible evidence that Communism as we knew it was approaching the brink of collapse, not only in the Soviet Union but throughout the Eastern bloc. The Soviet economy was being held together with baling wire; it was a basket case, partly because of massive spending on armaments. In Poland and other Eastern-bloc countries, the economies were also a mess, and there were rumblings of nationalistic fervor within the captive Soviet empire.

You had to wonder how long the Soviets could keep their empire intact. If they didn't make some changes, it seemed clear to me that in time Communism would collapse of its own weight, and I wondered how we as a nation could use these cracks in the Soviet system to accelerate the process of collapse.

Responding to the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, Jimmy Carter had imposed an embargo on the shipment of American grain to the Soviet Union. Although I supported the idea of sending a strong message of disapproval to Moscow, I suspected the embargo had probably hurt our farmers more than it hurt the Russians, because some of our allies had simply come in and filled the breach and supplied the grain that the Soviet Union needed. I was inclined to lift the embargo to help our farmers, but it wasn't an easy decision; I didn't want to send a message that we approved of what the Russians were doing. In theory, expanding trade was supposed to make the Soviets more moderate, but as far as I could tell, it had simply allowed them to spend fewer resources on agriculture and consumer goods and more on armaments.

Lifting the embargo would be a big boost to our farmers and help our economy at a time when it needed help, but